

Tune Analysis

10 Latin Jazz & Tango Standards — Chord-to-Scale Mapping

For each chord, the recommended scale from your syllabus is shown. Practice the tune by playing through the form using these scale choices.

1. Oye Como Va

Tito Puente | Key: A Dorian | Form: 2-chord vamp (open) | Time: 4/4 Cha-cha | Difficulty: Beginner

Bars	Chord	Scale Choice	Notes
1-2	Am7	A Dorian: A B C D E F# G	The workhorse — emphasize the F# (natural 6th)
3-4	D9	D Mixolydian: D E F# G A B C	Or stay on A Dorian — same notes!

Why this tune: Perfect beginner tune. Two chords, infinite possibilities. Am7-D9 is a i-IV vamp in A Dorian. Since both chords share the same notes (A Dorian = D Mixolydian), you can play A Dorian or A minor pentatonic over the entire tune.

Practice tip: Start with A minor pentatonic only. Then add the F# (Dorian 6th). Then try A Blues scale for grit. Focus on RHYTHM over note choice — this tune is all about the groove.

2. Senor Blues

Horace Silver | Key: Eb minor | Form: 12-bar minor blues | Time: 6/8 Afro-Cuban | Difficulty: Beginner-Intermediate

Bars	Chord	Function	Scale Choice
1-2	Ebm6/9	i	Eb Dorian: Eb F Gb Ab Bb C Db
3-4	Ebm6/9	i	Eb Minor Pentatonic: Eb Gb Ab Bb Db
5-6	Cb9 (B9)	bVI	Cb Mixolydian: Cb Db Eb Fb Gb Ab Bbb
7-8	Ebm6/9	i	Eb Blues: Eb Gb Ab A Bb Db
9	Bb7	V	Bb Spanish/Jewish: Bb Cb D Eb F Gb Ab
10	Ab7	IV	Ab Mixolydian: Ab Bb C Db Eb F Gb
11-12	Ebm6/9	i	Eb Dorian or Eb Minor Pentatonic

Why this tune: Bridges blues and latin jazz vocabulary. The 6/8 Afro-Cuban feel teaches you to think in a different rhythmic grid. The bVI chord (Cb9) is a classic minor blues move.

Practice tip: Eb minor pentatonic works over the entire form. Add Dorian for color. On the Bb7 (bar 9), try Spanish/Jewish for that latin V7 sound. The 6/8 feel means thinking in groups of 3.

3. Stolen Moments

Oliver Nelson | Key: C minor | Form: 12-bar minor blues + chromatic passage | Time: 4/4 | Difficulty: Intermediate

Bars	Chord	Function	Scale Choice
1-4	Cm7 / Cm6	i	C Dorian: C D Eb F G A Bb
5-6	Fm7 / Fm6	iv	F Dorian: F G Ab Bb C D Eb
7-8	Cm7 / Cm6	i	C Dorian or C Minor Pentatonic
9	Dm7(b5)	ii (of V)	D Locrian #2: D E F G Ab Bb C
10	G7(b13)	V	G Spanish/Jewish: G Ab B C D Eb F
11-12	Cm7 / Cm6	i	C Dorian

Chromatic Passage (the signature section):

Bar	Chord	Scale Choice
13	Dm11 / Ebm11	D Dorian / Eb Dorian (shift up a half step)
14	Em11 / Fm11	E Dorian / F Dorian (shift up a half step)
15	F#m11 / Fm11	F# Dorian / F Dorian (shift back down)
16	Em11 / Ebm11	E Dorian / Eb Dorian (continue descent)

Practice tip: The chromatic passage is a Dorian scale shifting up by half steps then back down. Practice Dorian in ALL keys — this tune tests whether you can move between them fluidly.

4. Besame Mucho

Consuelo Velazquez | Key: D minor | Form: ABA | Time: 4/4 Bolero | Difficulty: Intermediate

Bars	Chord	Function	Scale Choice
A: 1-2	Dm6	i	D Harmonic Minor: D E F G A Bb C#
3-4	Gm6	iv	G Dorian: G A Bb C D E F
5-6	Gm6 / D7(b9)	iv / V/iv	D7b9: D Spanish/Jewish: D Eb F# G A Bb C
7-8	Em7(b5) / A7(b9)	ii-V	Em7b5: E Locrian #2 / A7b9: A Spanish/Jewish
9-10	Dm6	i	D Melodic Minor: D E F G A B C#
11-12	A7(b9) / D7(b9)	V / V/iv	A Spanish: A Bb C# D E F G
13-14	Gm6	iv	G Harmonic Minor: G A Bb C D Eb F#
15-16	Bm7(b5) / E7(b9) / A7(b9)	ii-V-V	B Locrian #2 / E Spanish / A Spanish
Bars	Chord	Function	Scale Choice
B: 1-2	Gm6	iv	G Dorian: G A Bb C D E F
3-4	Dm6	i	D Harmonic Minor
5-6	Em7(b5) / A7(b9)	ii-V	E Locrian #2 / A Spanish/Jewish
7-8	Dm6 / D7(b9)	i / V/iv	D Harm Minor / D Spanish

Why this tune: A masterclass in minor key harmony. Almost every dominant chord is a V7(b9) — perfect for drilling Spanish/Jewish scale. The Dm6 tonic invites both Harmonic Minor and Melodic Minor.

Practice tip: This tune is FULL of Spanish/Jewish opportunities. Practice A Spanish (A Bb C# D E F G) and D Spanish (D Eb F# G A Bb C) until they are automatic. The Em7(b5)-A7(b9)-Dm cadence appears repeatedly — this is the minor ii-V-i from Phase 2.

5. Tin Tin Deo

Chano Pozo / Gil Fuller / Dizzy Gillespie | Key: C minor | Form: AABA (32 bars) | Time: 4/4 Afro-Cuban | Difficulty: Intermediate

Intro Vamp (Latin feel):

Bars	Chord	Scale Choice
1-2	Cm7	C Dorian: C D Eb F G A Bb
3-4	Dm7(b5) / G7(b9)	D Locrian #2: D E F G Ab Bb C / G Spanish: G Ab B C D Eb F

A Section:

Bars	Chord	Function	Scale Choice
1-2	Cm7	i	C Dorian

Bars	Chord	Function	Scale Choice
3-4	Fm7	iv	F Dorian: F G Ab Bb C D Eb
5	Dm7(b5)	ii	D Locrian #2: D E F G Ab Bb C
6	G7(b9)	V	G Spanish/Jewish: G Ab B C D Eb F
7-8	Cm7	i	C Minor Pentatonic: C Eb F G Bb

B Section (Bridge):

Bars	Chord	Function	Scale Choice
1-2	Ebmaj7	III	Eb Major: Eb F G Ab Bb C D
3-4	Abmaj7	VI	Ab Lydian: Ab Bb C D Eb F G
5-6	Dm7(b5)	ii	D Locrian #2
7-8	G7(b9)	V	G Spanish/Jewish or G Altered

Practice tip: The A section is a textbook minor jazz progression: i-iv-ii-V-i. The bridge lifts to the relative major (Eb). Practice switching between C Dorian (A section) and Eb Major (bridge) smoothly.

6. Obsesion

Pedro Flores | Key: A minor | Form: AB (32 bars) | Time: 4/4 Bolero | Difficulty: Intermediate

Bars	Chord	Function	Scale Choice
A: 1-2	Am	i	A Harmonic Minor: A B C D E F G#
3-4	F	VI	F Major: F G A Bb C D E
5-6	E7	V	E Spanish/Jewish: E F G# A B C D
7-8	Am	i	A Dorian: A B C D E F# G
9-10	Am	i	A Minor Pentatonic: A C D E G
11-12	G7	VII	G Mixolydian: G A B C D E F
13-14	C	III	C Major: C D E F G A B
15-16	Dm / Am	iv / i	D Dorian / A Harmonic Minor
Bars	Chord	Function	Scale Choice
B: 1-4	Am / F	i / VI	A Harm Minor / F Major
5-6	E7	V	E Spanish/Jewish
7-8	Am	i	A Harmonic Minor
9-10	A7	V/iv	A Mixolydian: A B C# D E F# G
11-12	G7	VII	G Mixolydian
13-14	C	III	C Major
15-16	E7 / Am	V / i	E Spanish / A Harmonic Minor

Practice tip: The bVI-V-i movement (F-E7-Am) is a classic tango/bolero cadence. Emphasize the G# in E Spanish/Jewish — it's the leading tone that pulls everything home to Am.

7. Caravan

Juan Tizol / Duke Ellington | Key: Fm / Ab major | Form: AABA (32 bars) | Time: 4/4 Latin/Swing | Difficulty: Intermediate

A Section (8 bars) — The exotic vamp:

Bars	Chord	Scale Choice	Notes
1-6	C7(b9)	C Spanish/Jewish: C Db E F G Ab Bb	THIS is the Caravan sound — Spanish scale for 6 bars
7-8	Fm6	F Harmonic Minor: F G Ab Bb C Db E	Resolution — the E natural pulls to F

B Section / Bridge (8 bars) — Swing feel, cycle of dominants:

Bars	Chord	Function	Scale Choice
1-2	F7	V/ii	F Mixolydian: F G A Bb C D Eb
3-4	Bb7	V/V	Bb Mixolydian: Bb C D Eb F G Ab
5-6	Eb7	V	Eb Mixolydian: Eb F G Ab Bb C Db
7-8	Ab6	I	Ab Major: Ab Bb C Db Eb F G

Why this tune: THE Spanish/Jewish scale showcase. You sit on C7(b9) for 6 bars — pure Phrygian Dominant territory. The bridge shifts to Ab major with a cycle of dominants (Mixolydian practice). Two completely different sounds in one tune.

Practice tip: On the A section, learn to milk the C Spanish scale: C Db E F G Ab Bb. The Db-E augmented 2nd IS the Caravan sound. On the bridge, switch to Mixolydian mode thinking. Try Bebop Dominant for flowing lines over the cycle.

8. Libertango

Astor Piazzolla | Key: A minor | Form: AB (repeating) | Time: 4/4 Tango (136 BPM) | Difficulty: Intermediate

A Section (8 bars) — The iconic tango riff:

Bars	Chord	Function	Scale Choice
1-2	Am	i	A Harmonic Minor: A B C D E F G#
3-4	E7	V	E Spanish/Jewish: E F G# A B C D
5-6	Dm	iv	D Dorian: D E F G A B C
7-8	Am	i	A Minor Pentatonic: A C D E G

B Section (8 bars) — Opens up to relative major area:

Bars	Chord	Function	Scale Choice
1-2	Dm	iv	D Dorian or D Melodic Minor
3-4	G7	VII	G Mixolydian: G A B C D E F
5-6	C (Cmaj7)	III	C Major: C D E F G A B
7-8	E7	V	E Spanish/Jewish or E Altered

The A section bass line descends chromatically: A - G# - G - F# - F - E. This implies passing diminished chords. Over the chromatic descent, use A Harmonic Minor throughout.

Practice tip: Use 3-3-2 rhythmic grouping. The B section Dm-G7-C is a ii-V-I in C major — contrast the tango A with a jazzier B section. On the final E7, try E Altered for maximum tension before returning to Am.

9. Oblivion

Astor Piazzolla | Key: C minor | Form: ABA | Time: 4/4 Slow milonga | Difficulty: Intermediate-Advanced

A Section (16 bars) — Descending minor cycle:

Bars	Chord	Function	Scale Choice
1-2	Cm	i	C Melodic Minor: C D Eb F G A B
3-4	Fm7	iv	F Dorian: F G Ab Bb C D Eb
5-6	Bb7	VII	Bb Mixolydian: Bb C D Eb F G Ab
7-8	Ebmaj7	III	Eb Major: Eb F G Ab Bb C D
9-10	Abmaj7	VI	Ab Lydian: Ab Bb C D Eb F G
11-12	Dm7(b5)	ii	D Locrian #2: D E F G Ab Bb C
13-14	G7	V	G Spanish/Jewish: G Ab B C D Eb F
15-16	Cm	i	C Harmonic Minor: C D Eb F G Ab B

B Section (16 bars):

Bars	Chord	Function	Scale Choice
1-2	Cm	i	C Dorian: C D Eb F G A Bb
3-4	Fm	iv	F Dorian or F Harmonic Minor
5-6	G7(sus4) / G7	V	G Mixolydian then G Spanish
7-8	Cm	i	C Melodic Minor
9-10	Abmaj7	VI	Ab Major or Ab Lydian
11-12	Bb7	VII	Bb Bebop Dominant
13-14	Ebmaj7	III	Eb Major
15-16	G7	V	G Altered: G Ab Bb B Db Eb F

Why this tune: A masterpiece of tango harmony. The A section is a full cycle through the key of C minor (i-iv-VII-III-VI-ii-V-i) — you touch almost every diatonic chord. This is the ultimate minor key navigation exercise.

Practice tip: Play slowly (this is a milonga, not a fast tango). Use Melodic Minor on the tonic for a smooth, modern sound. Switch to Harmonic Minor at the end of the A section for dramatic resolution. The Dm7(b5)-G7 is your Phase 2 ii-V in minor.

10. Desafinado

Antonio Carlos Jobim | Key: F major | Form: AABC (68 bars) | Time: 4/4 Bossa nova | Difficulty: Advanced

A Section (16 bars) — Chromatic ii-V motion:

Bars	Chord	Function	Scale Choice
1-2	Fmaj7	I	F Major: F G A Bb C D E
3-4	G7(b5)	subV/vi	G Lydian Dominant: G A B C# D E F
5-6	Gm7 / C7	ii-V	G Dorian / C Bebop Dominant
7-8	Am7(b5) / D7(b9)	iii-VI(alt)	A Locrian #2 / D Spanish/Jewish
9-10	Gm7 / A7(b13)	ii / V/ii	G Dorian / A Altered
11-12	Bbmaj7 / Bbm6	IV / iv	Bb Major / Bb Dorian
13-14	Fmaj7	I	F Major or F Lydian
15-16	G7(b5) / Gb7	subV / bII7	G Lyd Dom / Gb Lydian Dominant

B Section — Modulation to A major then Ab major:

Bars	Chord	Function	Scale Choice
17-18	Fmaj7	I (home)	F Major
19-20	E7(#9)	V/iii (to A)	E Altered: E F G G# Bb C D
21-22	Amaj7	new I	A Major: A B C# D E F# G#
23-24	Bb7(#11)	subV (to A)	Bb Lydian Dominant: Bb C D E F G Ab
25-26	Amaj7	I (A major)	A Major
27-28	Bbm7 / Eb7	ii-V (to Ab)	Bb Dorian / Eb Bebop Dominant
29-30	Abmaj7	new I	Ab Major: Ab Bb C Db Eb F G
31-32	Db7	subV (to C)	Db Lydian Dominant
33-36	Cmaj7 / C#dim7 / Dm7 / G7	V area	C Major / Dim / G Dorian / G Bebop Dom

C Section returns to F major with the same A-section material, resolving through Am7(b5)-D7(b9)-Gm7 cadences.

Why this tune: The harmonic Everest of bossa nova. It modulates through F, A, and Ab major using tritone substitutions (Lydian Dominant territory) and altered dominants. This tune uses nearly EVERY scale in your syllabus.

Practice tip: Break it into 8-bar chunks. Master each modulation separately. The Lydian Dominant scale is crucial here — use it on every b5 or #11 dominant. The E7(#9) to Amaj7 is a classic altered dominant resolution. This is a Phase 4 tune — don't rush to it.

Tune Difficulty Progression

Suggested order for learning these tunes:

Order	Tune	Key Concept Practiced	Phase
1	Oye Como Va	Dorian vamp, pentatonic, rhythm focus	Phase 1
2	Senor Blues	Minor blues, Dorian + pentatonic, 6/8 feel	Phase 1
3	Stolen Moments	Minor blues + chromatic Dorian shifts	Phase 1-2
4	Libertango	Harmonic minor, tango rhythm, Spanish/Jewish	Phase 2
5	Caravan	Spanish/Jewish vamp, cycle of dominants	Phase 2
6	Besame Mucho	Minor ii-V-i, Spanish/Jewish everywhere	Phase 2
7	Tin Tin Deo	Full minor jazz form, Afro-Cuban	Phase 2-3
8	Obsesion	Bolero, bVI-V-i cadences	Phase 2-3
9	Oblivion	Full minor cycle, Melodic Minor, tango phrasing	Phase 3
10	Desafinado	Modulations, Lydian Dominant, Altered, all scales	Phase 4